# Three revenue drivers

Product development plan · Groundwork by Jalla · 24 October 2026

**FOR PHILIP · FOLLOWING THE REVIEW CALL OF 23 OCTOBER**

The 23 October call replaced a subscription business with a results business: project management, tracking, budgets, estimates and documents become free, and Groundwork charges only for verification, for bidding, and for winning a project. This plan says what has to be built for that, by when, what each date rests on, and what I am deliberately not building. It is written so the dates can be held — which means the things that could break them are named rather than buried.

## 1 The answer in one page

| DRIVER | TODAY | TO BUILD | DATE | BIGGEST RISK |
|---|---|---|---|---|
| **Verification** 1.5% of stage cost | PART BUILT Verifier role, invites, assignment, inspection and certificates all exist. Never run with a real verifier. No charge of any kind. | Per-stage charging; field test; lift the one-verifier-per-stage limit | **End Nov** | No verifiers recruited yet |
| **Contractor bidding** credits | NOTHING No tables, no code, no screens. | Credits, purchase, bid window, minimum-bid rule, submission, selection | **End Dec** | Client-side rules undecided |
| **Win commission** 0.25% of project | NOTHING | Charge on award | **End Dec** | Cannot start before bidding |

> **Before any of that: we have never successfully taken a payment**
>
> There are **198 payment rows on the live system. None has settled. None carries a payment provider.** Ten are marked funded by staff confirming a client said they paid; the rest are scheduled milestones nobody has collected.
>
> All three drivers end in a charge. Verification at 1.5% a stage is a charge per request. Credits are a purchase. The commission is an invoice on award. **A finished build with no working collection rail earns nothing**, so I have put this first rather than inside the verification section. It is not a feature risk; it is the floor under all three.

| 198 | 0 |
|---|---|
| PAYMENT ROWS | EVER SETTLED |

## 2 What changes commercially

The old model sold access. The new model sells outcomes. Everything that used to justify a subscription is now free, and revenue only appears when something actually happens.

| | UNTIL NOW | FROM THIS PLAN |
|---|---|---|
| **Project management, tracking, budgets, estimates, documents** | Bundled into a paid tier | **Free** |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Plans** | Jalla Free / Jalla Verify / Jalla Management | **None.** Philip: *"our current model … becomes obsolete"* |
| **Subscription** | $199 a month | **Removed** |
| **Fee on each milestone payment** | 10% free tier / 3% paid tier | **Removed** — it belonged to the tiers, and the tiers are gone |
| **Verification** | Included in the tier | **1.5% of that stage's cost**, charged when requested |
| **Bidding** | — | **Credits**, bought and spent per bid |
| **Winning a project** | — | **5% of the contractor's 5%** |

> **Say the commission out loud carefully**
>
> The contractor takes 5% of project value; Groundwork charges 5% *of that*. On a $150,000 project the contractor earns $7,500 and pays Groundwork **$375 — which is 0.25% of the project**, not 5%.
>
> Spoken as "a 5% commission" it sounds twenty times larger than it is. A contractor who hears the first version will refuse before anyone gets to the second. Whatever language we settle on, it should carry the figure, not the percentage.

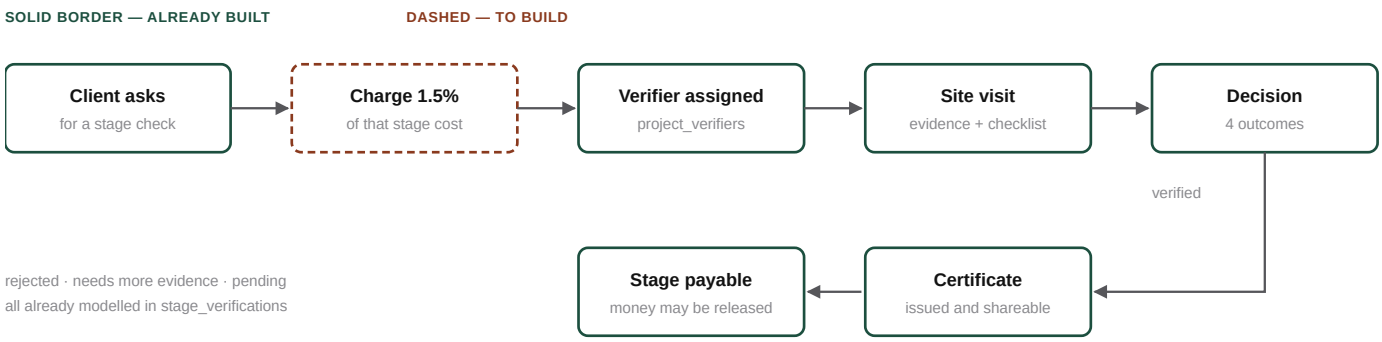
### What this is worth per project

| LINE | BASIS | ON $150,000 (THE MODEL) | ON $106,427 (REAL MEAN TODAY) |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Verification** | 1.5% × 8 stages | $2,250.00 | $1,596.41 |
| **Bidding** | 10 credits × $0.85 × 5 bids | $42.50 | $42.50 |
| **Commission** | 5% of the contractor's 5% | $375.00 | $266.07 |
| **Total** | | **$2,667.50** | **$1,904.98** |

The right-hand column is the same model run against the 24 real projects on the system, whose mean budget is $106,427 and median $91,654. Only four of them reach $150,000. The model is not wrong to use $150,000 — it describes the diaspora project we are aiming at, not the mix we have today — but the gap is worth knowing before it is quoted to an investor.

## 3 Driver one — Verification

The largest driver by revenue and the furthest along by code. It is also the one whose date depends least on engineering and most on people we have not yet recruited.




Verification, end to end. Only the charge is new; everything else exists and has been exercised in code but never with a real verifier on a real site.

## What exists today

| PIECE | WHERE | STATE |
|---|---|---|
| **Verifier accounts** | `verifier_profiles`, `verifier_invites` | BUILT Invite, sign-up and profile all work |
| **Assignment to a project** | `project_verifiers` | BUILT Plus an email on assignment |
| **The inspection record** | `stage_verifications` | BUILT Request, visit, checklist, findings, four decisions |
| **Certificates** | `certificates` | BUILT Issued on a verified decision |
| **Verifier workspace** | /verifiers | BUILT Work list and recording screen |
| **Any charge at all** | — | NOTHING Verification is free today |
| **Tested with a real verifier** | — | NEVER Exercised in code only |

## What has to be built

1. **A price on a stage check.** 1.5% of that stage's cost, computed at the moment of request and shown before the client commits. Philip's example: a $8,000 foundation costs $120 to verify. This is a new charge type — nothing in the product currently bills per event rather than per month.
2. **Collection.** The charge has to be taken. See section 7; this is the dependency, not the arithmetic.
3. **Two disciplines on one stage.** A unique index, `stage_verifications_one_pending_per_stage`, allows only one pending check per stage. A structural engineer and a quantity surveyor cannot both be mid-inspection on the same foundation. That is a real constraint for anything larger than a house and it has to lift before we sell verification as a product.
4. **A refund or waiver path.** If a client pays for a check and the verifier never attends, or the stage is rejected on our error, there must be a way to put the money back. Charging per event without that is how a support queue becomes unmanageable.

### The date, and what holds it

> **End of November**, as committed on the call — on three conditions, each of which has an owner who is not me:
>
> - **Verifiers exist to test with by 10 November.** Recruited, background-checked, trained. If they arrive 1 December, the date becomes mid-December. *Owner: Ruth.*
> - **A collection rail works by 17 November.** Without it I can build the charge and never prove it. *Owner: Philip (provider decision), me (integration).*
> - **Core project management stays stable.** Philip put this condition himself and I accept it. Ruth confirmed on the call that it is holding.

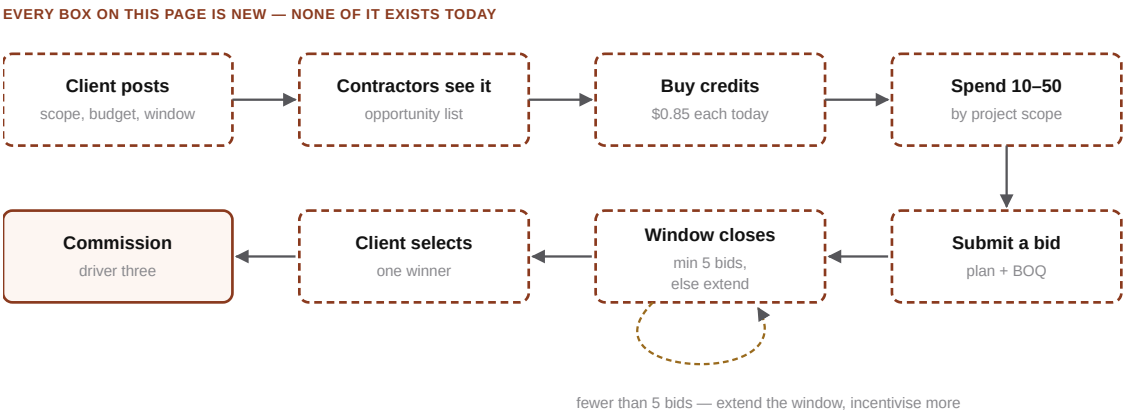
### How we will know it worked

Not "tests pass". **A real verifier attends a real site, records a decision, a certificate is issued, and a real client has paid the 1.5%.** The Q4 objective of fifteen verified projects is the proper test of this driver, and I would judge the November date against the first of those fifteen, not against a green build.

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## 4 Driver two — Contractor bidding

Nothing exists. No tables, no code, no screens. It is the largest build of the three and the only one whose shape is still partly undecided — and the undecided parts are product questions, not engineering ones, so they need answering before the build rather than during it.




Bidding, as described on the call. The dashed loop is the extension rule; the amber box below it is the unresolved case.

> **The hole Ruth found**
>
> A client who needs to start within 30 days cannot wait for a bid window to fill. None of the rules below answer that case, and it is the one Ruth has already met.

### What is settled, and what is not

| RULE | DECIDED ON THE CALL | STILL OPEN |
|---|---|---|
| **Credit price** | 500 XAF ($0.85) | Philip said it *"would likely change"* to 1,000 XAF ($1.60). Likely, not decided — the model still uses $0.85 |
| **Credits per bid** | Minimum 10, up to 50 by scope | What determines the band, and who sets it |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Bids per project** | Minimum 5, sometimes 10–15 | Who chooses, and on what basis |
| **Bid window** | Set by the client at posting | Allowed range. A 3-day window with a 5-bid minimum cannot succeed |
| **Extension** | Extend if the minimum is not met | How many times, how long, and who approves |
| **Urgent projects** | — | **Unanswered.** Ruth's case: the client who must start inside the window |
| **Refunds** | — | Are credits returned if the project is cancelled, or if the window expires unfilled? |
| **Losing bidders** | — | They have paid and lost. Do they learn why? Anything at all? |

> **The question I would answer first**
>
> What happens when a bid window expires without the minimum? Three choices, and they lead to different products: **extend** (the client waits, which may lose them), **release at a lower minimum** (the client picks from three bids instead of five), or **fall back to direct assignment** (Groundwork offers a contractor, and no bidding revenue is earned).
>
> It is worth deciding now because it changes the data model. A project that can leave the bidding flow needs a state for having done so, and retrofitting that later is more expensive than designing it in.

## What has to be built

| PIECE | NOTES |
|---|---|
| **Credit ledger** | Balance per contractor, every purchase and spend recorded. Must balance exactly — this is money, and a credit that vanishes is a support call we cannot answer |
| **Credit purchase** | A real checkout. Depends on the collection rail in section 7 |
| **Opportunity listing** | What a contractor sees before paying. Enough to judge whether to spend credits, not so much that the bid is worthless |
| **Bid submission** | Architectural plan and bill of quantities. We already parse BOQ spreadsheets for project creation, so that part is reusable |
| **Window and minimum** | Scheduled close, extension rule, and the expiry case above |
| **Client review and selection** | Compare bids side by side; one winner |
| **Award** | Marks the winner, triggers driver three, and closes the project to further bids |

## The date

**End of December** for the structure built and internally testable. Its first genuine test is a real client posting a real project and real contractors paying to bid on it, which needs project volume we will not have before the new year. I would rather write that down now than report it as a surprise in January.

## 5 Driver three — Win commission

The smallest build of the three and the last, because the award that triggers it only exists once bidding does.

| PIECE | NOTES |
|---|---|
| **Commission record** | What was owed, on which project, to which contractor, when |
| **Charge on award** | 5% of the contractor's 5%. Computed from the winning bid value, not the client's budget — those differ, and the bid is the number both sides agreed |
| **Collection and chasing** | A commission is owed by a contractor who has just won work and not yet been paid for it. Timing matters: invoicing on award and collecting on first milestone is likely kinder and likelier to be paid |
| **Reversal** | The project is cancelled after award. The commission has to be refundable |

> **One decision for Philip**
>
> **When is the commission actually taken?** On award, when the contractor has won but earned nothing — or on the first milestone payment, when money has moved. The model assumes the revenue exists either way; the collection rate will not be the same. I would recommend first milestone, and flag that it pushes some 2027 revenue into later months.

## 6 Removing the plans — what goes and what stays

Philip: *"our current model where we have the Jalla Free, Jalla Verify and Jalla Management becomes obsolete."* That is a decision about what we sell. It is not the same as a decision about a database column, and conflating the two would turn a one-day change into a week of risk for no visible gain.

| | EFFORT | WHAT A CUSTOMER NOTICES | RECOMMENDATION |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Remove plans, prices, the upgrade screen, the $199, the 10%/3% fee** | Small and safe | **Everything.** This is the change Philip asked for | DO IT |
| **Delete the `tier` column** | 24 migrations, 44 source files, a row-level security policy | **Nothing.** Nobody sees a column | LEAVE IT |

Three live projects are `jalla_management`, which is a genuinely different engagement — negotiated, hands-on, not self-serve. Deleting the column would erase a real distinction to achieve something invisible. My recommendation is that the tier survives as an **internal marker of how we are serving a project**, and disappears completely from what anyone outside the company sees.

> **A consequence that falls out of this, which nobody has raised**
>
> The free plan allows **three projects**, and that limit hangs off the tier. Today, a client who hits it is offered Jalla Verify. From this plan onward **there is nothing to offer them** — everything is already free.
>
> So the limit either goes, or it stays as abuse protection with completely different wording. It cannot stay as it is, because it currently points at a product that will not exist. I would keep a limit, raise it, and reword it as a fair-use ceiling rather than a paywall — but this is Philip's call and it needs making before the plans come out, not after a client hits it.

## 7 The floor — getting paid

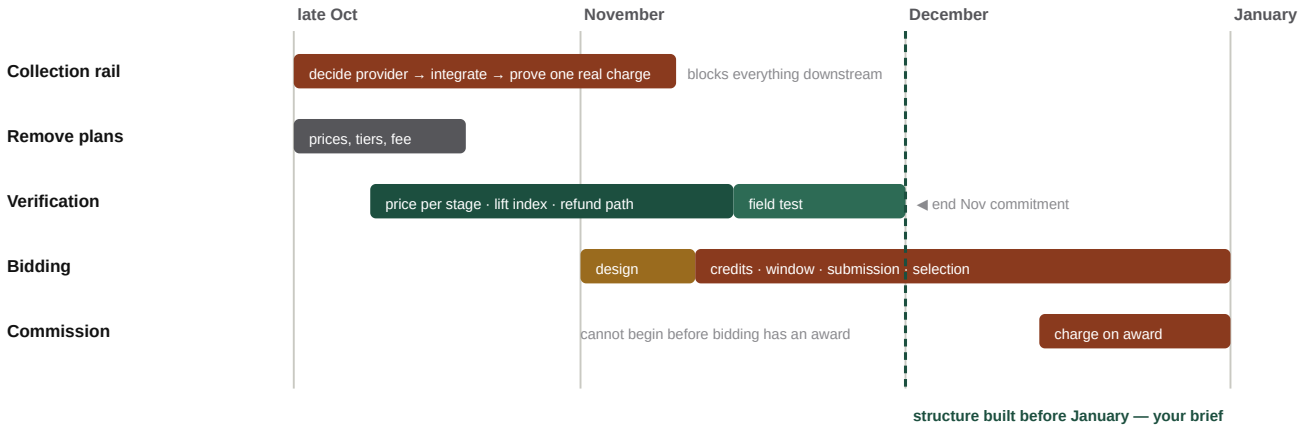
Every driver in this plan ends in a charge, and we have never completed one.

| DRIVER | WHAT HAS TO BE COLLECTED | FROM WHOM | WHEN |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Verification** | 1.5% of a stage cost, per request | Client, often diaspora | Many small charges across a 7–12 month project |
| **Bidding** | Credit purchases | Contractor, in Cameroon | Up front, in XAF |
| **Commission** | 5% of the contractor's 5% | Contractor, in Cameroon | On award, or first milestone |

Those are two different problems. A diaspora client paying from abroad is a card payment and Stripe is already wired for subscriptions. A Cameroonian contractor buying credits is mobile money in XAF, which is the SwyChr path and **has never written a row to the ledger.** Verification revenue depends on the first; both of the others depend on the second.

> **This is the single thing most likely to make an on-time build worthless.** I can deliver verification charging by the end of November and still collect nothing in December. The decision about which rail carries which charge is not mine, and I have put a date against it in section 9 because it sits on the critical path for all three drivers.

## 8 Sequence




Verification carries a November commitment because it is already part built. Bidding needs its rules decided in November before the build can start in earnest.

## 9 What this plan depends on, and who owns it

These are stated as conditions on my dates, not as complaints. If one slips, the date behind it slips, and this table is so that is visible in October rather than discovered in December.

| DEPENDENCY | NEEDED BY | OWNER | IF IT IS LATE |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Payment provider decided for XAF collection** | 3 Nov | Philip | Credits and commission cannot be collected; bidding ships unable to earn |
| **A collection rail proven end to end** | 17 Nov | Me, once the provider is chosen | Verification builds but cannot be charged; November date becomes a build-only date |

| | | | |
|---|---|---|---|
| **Verifiers recruited, cleared, trained** | 10 Nov | Ruth | Verification cannot be field tested; end of November becomes mid-December |
| **Bidding rules answered (section 4)** | 14 Nov | Philip | Build starts on assumptions and is reworked |
| **Free-project limit decided (section 6)** | 7 Nov | Philip | A client hits a wall pointing at a product that no longer exists |
| **Core project management stays stable** | Throughout | Me | Philip's own condition; attention moves off revenue work |

## 10 What I am not building

Stated so it cannot be assumed. Each of these was mentioned somewhere in the call or the model, and none is in this plan.

| NOT BUILDING | WHY |
|---|---|
| **FX spread on international transfers** | Named as a future driver, not one of the three |
| **Payment processing fee** | Same |
| **Materials marketplace** | Philip described it as beyond the three; it is a product, not a feature |
| **A support chatbot** | Raised by Ruth for scale. Real need, not a revenue driver, and it competes directly with the November date |
| **Ghana and Nigeria launch work** | Budgeted for next year; no product work is scoped here |
| **Deleting the `tier` column** | Section 6 — invisible to customers, expensive and risky |
| **Re-signing the partner agreement** | Separately agreed. The current agreement still promises $50 per project per month to 61 people who accepted it, which contradicts the new model and needs closing — but it is a legal task, not a build |
| **The walkthrough video contractors keep asking for** | Thirty-odd people have asked. Worth doing, not mine inside this window unless it displaces something |

## 11 How we will know each one works

Each driver gets one test, and it is the same shape in every case: a real person, real money, no staff intervention.

| DRIVER | THE TEST THAT COUNTS | NOT SUFFICIENT |
|---|---|---|
| **Verification** | A client requests a check, pays the 1.5%, a verifier attends, records a decision and a certificate is issued — **fifteen times, as the Q4 objective requires** | Tests passing; a staff member recording a verification on a verifier's behalf |
| **Bidding** | A contractor buys credits with their own money, spends them, submits a bid, and a client picks a winner from at least five | Seeded credits; bids placed by us |

| | | |
|---|---|---|
| **Commission** | A winning contractor is charged and **the money arrives** | A commission row written and never collected |

> The distinction matters because of where we are today: **198 payment rows and nothing settled** is exactly what "built but never proven" looks like, and I would rather not add three more features in that state.

## 12 Decisions needed, with my recommendation

| # | DECISION | MY RECOMMENDATION | BY |
|---|---|---|---|
| **1** | Which rail collects XAF from contractors? | Settle it first. Nothing else in this plan earns money until it exists | 3 Nov |
| **2** | Credit price: stay at 500 XAF, or move to 1,000? | Stay at $0.85 for launch. The model is built on it, and raising the price of an unproven product before anyone has bought one is guessing twice | 14 Nov |
| **3** | What happens when a bid window expires under the minimum? | Release at a lower minimum rather than extend. A client who waits twice leaves | 14 Nov |
| **4** | The urgent client who cannot wait for a window | Allow a direct-assignment path that skips bidding and earns no bid revenue. Better to keep the project and lose $42 than to lose the project | 14 Nov |
| **5** | Commission charged on award, or on first milestone? | First milestone. A contractor who has won but not been paid will not pay us | 30 Nov |
| **6** | Does the three-project free limit survive? | Keep a limit, raise it, reword it as fair use. It cannot point at a paid plan that no longer exists | 7 Nov |
| **7** | Are losing bidders told anything? | Tell them the project was awarded, and nothing more. Silence after payment is how a marketplace earns a reputation | 14 Nov |

## 13 What I am committing to

| BY | COMMITMENT | CONDITIONAL ON |
|---|---|---|
| **31 Oct** | Plans, prices, the $199 and the milestone fee removed from everything a customer sees | Nothing |
| **17 Nov** | Verification priced at 1.5% per stage; the one-verifier-per-stage limit lifted; refund path in place | Collection rail decided by 3 Nov |
| **30 Nov** | Verification proven with a real verifier and a real paying client | Verifiers available from 10 Nov; rail working by 17 Nov |
| **31 Dec** | Bidding built and internally testable — credits, window, submission, selection | Rules answered by 14 Nov |
| **31 Dec** | Commission charged on award | Bidding complete |

> **One thing I want on the record**
>
> I said on the call that building verification and bidding side by side would take me to mid-January, and Philip asked for verification by the end of November instead. I have taken that date and I think it is achievable — **but only because verification is already largely built and the November work is pricing and proving it, not creating it.**
>
> What makes the date fragile is not the code. It is that we have never taken a payment and we have no verifiers. Both of those are being worked on by other people, and both sit in front of me on the critical path. If either is late, the honest thing is to move the date early rather than discover it on 28 November.